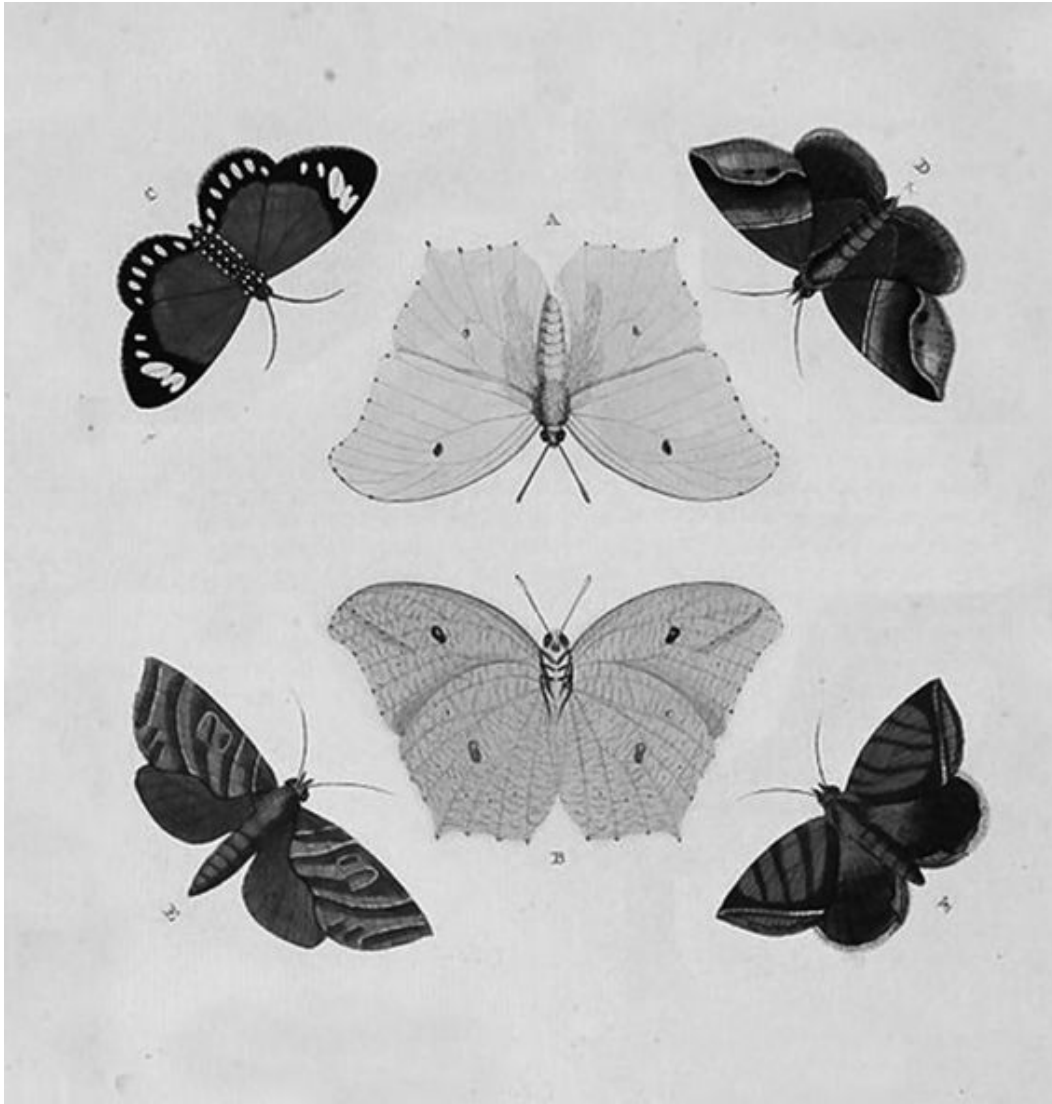


Scientific observation and classification



Aristotle was both a keen naturalist and an almost obsessive organizer. After Plato's death, he spent several years in Asia Minor studying the plants and animals. He identified characteristics, similarities and differences, and eventually produced a systematic classification of living things. Presented as a hierarchy from simple plants and animals to humans, it was later known as the *scala naturae* or the 'great chain of being'.

Aristotle also took an interest in the physical sciences, or 'natural philosophy', and advocated the same methodical approach: observation,

organization and a rational process of deriving conclusions. This was a radical departure from the pure reasoning advocated by previous philosophers and a major step towards a scientific method of examining the world. He applied the same approach to his philosophy as a whole, organizing and classifying his work in branches, but at the same time pointing out connections and building probably the first comprehensive system of philosophy.